The Great Society

President Lyndon B. Johnson · May 22, 1964

Source: Lyndon B. Johnson, Commencement Address at the University of Michigan (1964). Public domain. Continuous passage.

> At the University of Michigan, Johnson laid out his vision of a “Great Society” that would end poverty and racial injustice and renew American cities, countryside, and classrooms — the framework for his domestic reform agenda.

The Great Society rests on abundance and liberty for all. It demands an end to poverty and racial injustice, to which we are totally committed in our time. But that is just the beginning. The Great Society is a place where every child can find knowledge to enrich his mind and to enlarge his talents. It is a place where leisure is a welcome chance to build and reflect, not a feared cause of boredom and restlessness. It is a place where the city of man serves not only the needs of the body and the demands of commerce but the desire for beauty and the hunger for community. It is a place where man can renew contact with nature. It is a place which honors creation for its own sake and for what it adds to the understanding of the race. It is a place where men are more concerned with the quality of their goals than the quantity of their goods. But most of all, the Great Society is not a safe harbor, a resting place, a final objective, a finished work. It is a challenge constantly renewed, beckoning us toward a destiny where the meaning of our lives matches the marvelous products of our labor.